

GRAMMAR DETECTIVE CLASS

Subject–Verb Agreement

Finding the hidden rule in real sentences



*everyone is
neither likes
travels was*

Level A2 – B1 · Today's mission: become a grammar detective

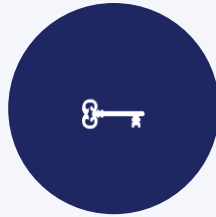
WARM-UP

Who Lives Here?



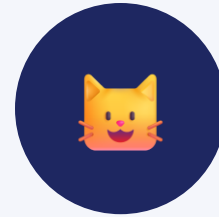
A Big Family

Many generations,
one table



Roommates

Sharing a small
apartment



Living Alone

Just one person
(and maybe a cat)

Look at the pictures. Who lives here? How many people? Is it noisy or quiet — easy or difficult to share?

WARM-UP

Alone or with a big family?

Would you rather live alone or with a big family?
Who do you live with right now?

Living alone

With one roommate

With a big family

With pets

READING

The Apartment on 5th Street

Part 1 of 2 — read for the story, not the grammar!

My name is Carla, and I live in the strangest apartment in New York. Everybody in my building has a story, but mine is the strangest. Neither of my roommates likes cooking, so the kitchen is always a mystery.

Each of us has a different job: one of us works nights, one of us studies, and one of us — my dog, Biscuit — just sleeps all day.

The pair of shoes by the door belongs to nobody I know. Along with the shoes, a stack of old magazines sits in the corner. Nobody remembers whose they are, and nothing gets thrown away in this apartment.

READING

The Apartment on 5th Street

Part 2 of 2

Either my landlord or my neighbors leave notes on our door every week. Not only the landlord but also the mail carrier thinks something strange is happening here.

Bread and butter always disappears from the fridge overnight. My friends think a ghost is responsible! Arabian Nights sits on our shelf, unread, collecting dust — everyone is too busy for books.

My roommate, together with her two cats, occupies the biggest room. As well as the cats, a parrot named Gulliver — yes, like Gulliver's Travels — lives with us too. Somebody, someday, needs to explain this apartment to me.

What Did You Understand?

Answer the questions

- 1 Who does Carla live with (people and animals)?
- 2 What is strange about the kitchen, the shoes, and the fridge?
- 3 Why do her friends think there's a ghost?

True or False?

Carla lives alone.

TRUE **FALSE**

Nobody knows whose shoes are by the door.

TRUE **FALSE**

Find the Pattern

Go back to the story. Highlight, circle, and underline as you go.



Subjects & Verbs

Highlight every verb. Draw an arrow back to the word that really “does” the verb — the true subject. Careful: other words sometimes sit in between!



Special Expressions

Circle phrases like Neither of / Either of / Each of / One of / Along with / Together with / As well as / Not only...but also. Look at the verb right after each one.



Tricky Pairs

Underline: bread and butter, Arabian Nights, Gulliver's Travels. Singular or plural verb? Does it surprise you?

Detective Worksheet

1

Find 4 sentences with “of” phrases (Neither of / Each of / One of...). Write the verb that follows each one.

2

Find 3 connecting phrases (Along with / Together with / As well as...). What comes right before and right after?

3

Find “bread and butter.” Is it is or are? Now find “my roommate, together with her two cats.” What's different?

4

Find “Arabian Nights” and “Gulliver's Travels.” They look plural — singular or plural verb? Why?

5

Find one sentence with everybody, nobody, or something. Singular or plural verb?

BUILD THE RULE — WORK IN GROUPS

Rule Builders (Part 1)

A *“Neither of my roommates likes cooking.” “Each of us has a different job.”*

After Neither of / Either of / Each of / One of + plural noun, the verb is **singular** (singular / plural).

B *“My roommate, together with her two cats, occupies the biggest room.”*

Phrases like together with / along with / as well as do NOT change the verb — it agrees with the word **before** the phrase.

C *“Bread and butter always disappears...” vs. “Bread and butter are sold in this super shop...”*

“A and B” is usually plural, except when the two things are really **one idea** (one idea / two ideas).

BUILD THE RULE — WORK IN GROUPS

Rule Builders (Part 2)

D “*Arabian Nights sits on our shelf.*” “*Gulliver's Travels... lives with us.*”

Titles that look plural (end in -s) still take a **singular** verb, because the title = one book.

E “*Everybody is too busy.*” “*Nobody remembers.*”

everyone / everybody / someone / something / no one / nobody / none... always take a **singular** verb.

F “*Either my landlord or my neighbors leave notes.*”

With either...or / neither...nor / not only...but also, the verb agrees with the subject **close** to it.

GOLDEN RULE: A singular subject needs a singular verb. A plural subject needs a plural verb. The tricky part is finding the head or main subject!

CONFIRMED RULES

The Rules We Found (1–4)

- 1 Golden Rule: singular subject → singular verb. Plural subject → plural verb.
- 2 Ignore words between the subject and the verb (prepositional / “of” phrases).
- 3 Neither of / Either of / Each of / One of + plural noun → singular verb.
- 4 Along with / together with / as well as / including / besides → verb agrees with the FIRST subject.

CONFIRMED RULES

The Rules We Found (5–8)

- 5 Either...or / neither...nor / not only...but also → verb agrees with the CLOSER subject.
- 6 Indefinite pronouns (everyone, nobody, something, etc.) → always singular.
- 7 “A and B” → usually plural, but singular when A and B are one single idea (bread and butter).
- 8 Book / story titles → always singular, even if they look plural (Arabian Nights).

PRACTICE A — CHOOSE THE CORRECT VERB

Gap-Fill

1. Neither of the twins (want / wants) to go first.

2. The book, along with three magazines, (is / are) on the table.

3. Everybody in the class (has / have) a phone.

4. Either the teacher or the students (choose / chooses) the topic.

5. Not only my sister but also my parents (love / loves) this song.

6. One of the workers (need / needs) a break.

7. Rice and beans (is / are) a common dish in my country.

8. Gulliver's Travels (tell / tells) the story of a strange journey.

9. The manager, accompanied by two assistants, (was / were) in the meeting.

10. Nobody (know / knows) the answer.

ANSWER KEY

Gap-Fill — Answers

1. wants

2. is

3. has

4. choose

5. love

6. needs

7. is (as a dish)

8. tells

9. was

10. knows

PRACTICE B — FIND AND FIX THE MISTAKE

Error Correction

1. Each of the students have their own laptop.

2. The coach, together with the players, are excited.

3. Everybody know the rules already.

4. Neither of the answers are correct.

5. Bread and butter are my favorite breakfast.

6. Arabian Nights are a famous collection of stories.

7. Either she or her brothers is coming tonight.

8. Besides the manager, the two clerks was late.

ANSWER KEY

Error Correction — Answers

1. have → has

2. are → is

3. know → knows

4. are → is

5. are → is

6. are → is

7. is → are (brothers is closer)

8. was → were (clerks is the subject)

Mystery Roommate

Step 1 — Build your household

- Neither of the roommates _____.
- Each of them _____.
- Along with [name], [name] _____.
- Either [person] or [person] _____.
- Everybody in the apartment _____.
- Their favorite book, _____, always _____.

Step 2 — Interview another pair

- Who lives in their apartment?
- What does neither of them like?
- What does everybody in their apartment do?
- Is their favorite food combo one dish or many?
- What book do they love? What happens in it?

HOMework

My Real (or Imaginary) Household

Write a short paragraph (8–10 sentences) describing the people (or animals!) you live with — real or invented. Use at least SIX of these structures, and underline each one:

☐ Neither of / Either of / Each of / One of

☐ An indefinite pronoun (everybody, nobody, something...)

☐ Along with / together with / as well as / including / besides

☐ A compound subject with “and” (check: one idea or two?)

☐ Either...or / neither...nor / not only...but also

☐ A book, movie, or show title as a subject